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The Ground Floor

Two of the UAE's best-located empty land parcels - read before their price sheets exist.

Jebel Ali Racecourse, Dubai · Lulu Island, Abu Dhabi

August 2026 · Prices indicative unless marked as transacted · Prepared as market intelligence, not financial advice

What's Coming

A 5 square kilometre masterplan by **A.R.M. Holding**, designed by **BIG - Bjarke Ingels Group**, announced May 2025 at a signing ceremony with A.R.M.'s CEO and Bjarke Ingels himself. Ground-break: **early 2026**. This is the transformation of the historic racecourse site into a new urban district aligned to the Dubai 2040 plan.

5 km²	8	~$5B	2026
MASTERPLAN AREA	WALKABLE NEIGHBOURHOODS	REPORTED PROJECT VALUE	GROUND-BREAK

The design thesis

"Urban islands in a sea of green" - eight mixed-use neighbourhoods densifying toward a vast central park that preserves the spatial memory of the original racetrack. A 10-minute city: schools, shops, transport, healthcare within a short walk. Microclimate engineering targets streets meaningfully cooler than the surrounding city. Equestrian heritage retained in the fabric.

Why the location is the whole story

The site sits in **Al Thanyah Second, between Sheikh Zayed Road and Al Khail Road -** Barsha Heights and The Greens on the north fence, **Emirates Hills and Hattan directly across First Al Khail**, the Meadows and Springs to the southwest, Al Barsha and Arjan to the east. Minutes from the foot of Palm Jumeirah and ~15 minutes to the Marina. It is the last empty 5 km² surrounded on every side by established, mature, fully-priced Dubai - the city is already there, on all four fences.

Inside the District

What it will contain

Beyond homes: a **"city-as-gym"** concept placing every resident within five minutes of green space and wellbeing centres · **urban farms and community markets** · flexible office space built into the neighbourhoods · **equestrian venues, museums and educational experiences** preserving the racing legacy · autonomous shuttles and transit connectivity. The residential mix is expected to span **apartments, townhouses and villas** set around the park and waterways.

Who's behind it

A.R.M. Holding - a multi-sector investment group whose real estate portfolio includes Dubai Real Estate Centre, Huna and Hive - with **BIG**, the practice behind Google's headquarters and 2 World Trade Center. Broker channels are already marketing the project informally as **"The Park Dubai"** and collecting expressions of interest, with the official sales launch and pricing release expected during 2026. That informal EOI market is itself a signal: the machine around this launch is already warming up.

Phasing - the window that matters

Delivery is phased: infrastructure and the central park first, then the **first residential neighbourhoods with early launches**. That first-phase launch is the entry event - historically, phase-one buyers in park-led masterplans capture the widest gap between launch pricing and the established ladder around them.

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The Price Ladder Around the Fence

The site is ringed by everything from ~Đ900/sqft apartments to Đ4,000+/sqft super-prime villas - the widest price ladder around any single plot in Dubai. Where new product prices within this ladder is the investment question.

ZONE (RELATIVE TO SITE)	TIER	INDICATIVE PRICING	SOURCE
Emirates Hills (across First Al Khail)	**Super-prime villas**	**Đ4,000+/sqft, entry ~Đ40M+**	**Market data, Aug-26**
Jumeirah Islands / Meadows (SW ring)	Established prime villas	Asks Đ10.5-20M (4-bed)	Live portal scan, Aug-26
Jumeirah Park / Springs (SW ring)	Established family villas	Asks Đ5.4-9.3M (4-bed)	Live portal scan, Aug-26
JGE 2.0 Cedarwood (new golf villas, 15 min)	New-launch benchmark	Đ2,200-3,000/sqft transacting sheet	Developer inventory, Aug-26
The Greens / Views + Barsha Heights (N fence)	Mid-market apartments	Đ1,300-1,800/sqft band	Market data, Aug-26
Al Barsha South / Arjan / JVC (E + SE)	Affordable apartments	Đ900-1,300/sqft band	Market data, Aug-26
Dubai citywide reference	All ready homes	Đ1,691/sqft avg transacted (+5.6% y/y)	ValuStrat Q1-26, published

The asking-side reality check

A live scan of 4-bed family villas within a **15-minute drive** of the site (790 active listings, Aug 2026): Springs asks **Đ5.4-7.8M** · Jumeirah Park **Đ8.1-9.3M** · Meadows **Đ10.5-15M** · Arabian Ranches ~**Đ11M** · Jumeirah Islands ~**Đ20M**. The newest established villa community in this ring is roughly twenty years old. Family demand at Đ8-15M is being served almost entirely by twenty-year-old stock - a brand-new, BIG-designed, park-led district lands directly into that demand pool.

The thesis

A park-led premium district does not price at the Barsha end of its ladder. Design pedigree (BIG), green density, and the Emirates Hills adjacency position first-phase product toward the **upper-middle of the ring** - while launch pricing, by definition, opens below where the finished product settles. The gap between those two numbers is the phase-one buyer's margin.

Transacted figures: Dubai Land Department open data · Asking figures: live portal scan Aug 2026

Where We Estimate It Prices

Nothing is launched and no price sheet exists - **everything on this page is our estimate**, anchored to three live benchmarks: new-launch golf villas at JGE 2.0 transacting Đ2,200-3,000/sqft; twenty-year-old Meadows villas asking ~Đ2,800-3,700/sqft; Emirates Hills above Đ4,000/sqft. Our expectation: **at maturity, only Emirates Hills in the immediate ring remains clearly above this district -** new build, BIG pedigree and park frontage price above old stock, and pressure on these numbers is upward.

EXPECTED PRODUCT	EST. SIZE (BUA)	EST. LAUNCH PSF	EST. ENTRY RANGE
Park-district apartments (1-2 bed)	800 - 1,500 sqft	Đ2,000 - 2,600	Đ1.8M - 3.6M
Townhouses (3 bed)	2,200 - 2,800 sqft	Đ2,000 - 2,500	Đ4.5M - 7M
3-bed villas	**2,800 - 3,600 sqft**	**Đ2,600 - 3,200**	**Đ7.5M - 11.5M**
4-bed villas	**3,800 - 5,000 sqft**	**Đ2,600 - 3,400**	**Đ10M - 16M**
Park-fronting / signature villas	5,000+ sqft	Đ3,200 - 4,000+	Đ16M+

Estimates, August 2026, before any official release. All figures revised the day the first price sheet lands.

Post-completion settle: with prime Dubai villa growth compounding through a ~4-year build, we expect handover values **30-50% above launch** - materially better than a typical launch-to-handover gap, because the ladder around this site is already mature and rising. On location, pedigree and that growth path, **we expect this district fits the plan.**

Expected structure

Payment plan: we expect a construction-weighted plan in the **60/40 or 50/50** family - but with a **heavier front door than most launches: likely ~20% on booking, plus the 4% DLD fee**, so realistic day-one cash is ~24% of price before anything else. Budget for that, not for a 10% teaser. First release likely one or two neighbourhoods with park-adjacent parcels held back - developers price-discover on the first island and ratchet the rest. **Phase-one economics are the best this district will ever offer.**

The realism check

These are **premium numbers**. A 4-bed villa here is a Đ10M+ decision - this district is not the affordable corner of the ladder and will not pretend to be. But on everything we can see - the location, the ladder, the growth path **- this will be a fantastic investment, and if we can make it work within the plan, we should.** The honest question is fit, not quality.

How To Play It

What it costs

Today: nothing to position. At launch: serious money. On our estimates a villa entry starts around Đ7.5M and runs well past Đ10M - premium pricing for a premium district. The honest question to settle BEFORE the price sheet arrives: is that bracket inside your capital plan? If yes, positioning now is free upside. If no, this stays a watch - **and we look elsewhere for villas, because villas are the better play**; the tier doesn't change, the postcode does. Launch allocation goes to the prepared, not the richest - but preparation only pays if the price point is genuinely yours.

The positioning checklist

- **Registration:** interest registered with A.R.M. channels the moment they open - Calum monitors and registers on your instruction.
- **Capital mapping:** your Income Plan already sequences your UK capital; a phase-one entry here would be weighed against the next planned rung, not added blindly on top.
- **Trigger watch (Calum monitors weekly):** launch registration opening · first price sheets · payment plan structure · which neighbourhood releases first (park-adjacent parcels are the prize).

The honest risks - in writing

- **Unlaunched pricing:** if A.R.M. prices phase one at the top of the ladder from day one, the margin thesis shrinks. We will know within minutes of the first price sheet.
- **Execution:** a 5 km^2 build takes the better part of a decade; early phases live beside construction for years.
- **Developer track record:** A.R.M. Holding is a major investment house but not a volume residential developer; delivery pace is unproven at this scale. The BIG partnership and government alignment mitigate, not eliminate, this.
- **Timing vs the September wave:** dozens of launches land across Dubai in Q4 2026 - competition for capital will be loud. Patience is a position too.

Bottom line: this is a watch-and-position play, not a buy-today play. The decision point arrives with the first price sheet - and the preparation that makes that decision fast costs nothing now.

Lulu Island - The Giant Is Waking

4.69 km² of reclaimed island, 500 metres off the Corniche, facing the skyline and Al Maryah's financial district - conceived by Sheikh Zayed as a keystone of the capital's growth, and the best-located undeveloped land in the UAE. Four decades of masterplans by world-name firms: **Oscar Niemeyer** (600+ designs, all rejected), **Arquitectonica** (75% resort-residential-cultural, 25% parkland and canals), **SOM** (the 75-storey clam tower), and **Sasaki's detailed masterplan - 16,000 homes for 30,000 residents in low-rise neighbourhoods where every residence sits within a five-minute walk of water**, with Neighbourhood 3 fully designed around a live-work marina. The renders circulating today trace to these plans. Ownership: Sorouh (60%) + Mubadala (40%) by 2008 decree - Sorouh's stake passing to **Aldar** in 2013. Nothing was ever built.

Why 2026 is different - the evidence, graded

CONFIRMED **An early-works contract on Lulu Island was awarded to a UAE firm in January 2026** (MEED, 22 Jan). Site activity was independently reported in late July. After forty years of paper, there are now machines. Development has started - what's unannounced is the masterplan and the name on it.

COMPETING ATTRIBUTIONS Market commentary places Lulu's revival inside **Modon's** masterplanning orbit alongside Hudayriyat's expansion and Ba Al Ghaylam; an industry project tracker lists **Eagle Hills** as developer; and the legacy owners **Aldar-Mubadala** hold a purpose-built island JV. Separately and officially, Eagle Hills is delivering the **Bvlgari Resort & Mansions** (ACPV Architects, 90 mansions, opening 2030) on a private island off Abu Dhabi. Any of the three could hold the pen; none has said so publicly.

UNANNOUNCED The current masterplan, the developer of record, product mix and any sales programme. Historic plans (Sasaki's 16,000 homes) indicate the SCALE the island can carry - not what will be built.

Why it matters to your plan

Abu Dhabi is running **+17.8% annually** (ValuStrat, Q2 2026) with apartments outpacing villas at **+24%**, Al Reem at **+22%**, and ValuStrat's research head on record that the capital sits **earlier in its property cycle than Dubai**. When Lulu's masterplan goes public - and January's contract award says that clock is running - the announcement effect lands first on the facing shorelines: the Corniche, Al Maryah, and Reem. Your existing Abu Dhabi exposure sits in the blast radius of good news.

The play

Watch, hold, position - spend nothing yet. Calum monitors WAM, Aldar, Mubadala, Eagle Hills and Modon channels weekly, plus construction-intelligence flow. If a public sales programme emerges, phase-one logic applies on the most valuable empty land in the country - and the announcement itself is a same-day call.

Sources: MEED (Jan-26 contract award), Sasaki/Arquitectonica published masterplans, decrees via WAM archive, ValuStrat Q2-26

SUMMARY

Actions & Watchlist

What Amer does now

ACTION	WHEN
Confirm appetite - as we speak: on our estimates, villa entry starts ~Đ7.5M+ - inside the plan, or do we hunt the villa tier elsewhere?	Now
Documents launch-ready	By end of year
Decide trigger rules in advance: "if phase-one villas open below Đ[X]/sqft, I'm in for Đ[Y]" - decided on shore, not in a showroom	Before first price sheet

Also this week: Calum is filming the Racecourse plot on the ground - current-state footage of the site before ground-break, for your file and the record.

What Calum monitors (standing, weekly)

WATCH	TRIGGER
A.R.M. Holding / Racecourse channels	Registration opening · first price sheet · launch neighbourhood
Lulu Island (WAM, Aldar, Mubadala, Eagle Hills, Modon + construction intelligence)	Masterplan/developer announcement or sales programme - same-day call
DLD transacted prices, full comp ring	Quarterly ladder refresh lands in your inbox
September-November launch wave	Anything competing for the same capital at better terms

The one-line thesis: two of the UAE's best-located empty land parcels are about to get developers and price sheets. Preparation costs nothing; being early to either is the entire opportunity. Your capital plan already has the rungs - this report tells you when a rung might be worth swapping.